Deployment Cost Estimate — Steady State After the Free Credit

Invoice → TallyPrime automation · Vercel Hobby (frontend) + Google Cloud Run (backend), with AWS migration comparison · 8 August 2026

$0.85 **per month** once the $300 credit is gone ≈ **₹81/mo** · **$10.20 / ₹971 per year**
Vercel Hobby $0 + Cloud Run compute $0 (inside always-free tier) + container image storage $0.85

Workload assumed: single CA office, ~2 concurrent users, **200 invoices/month** (150 digital PDFs @ ~3 s CPU, 50 scanned @ ~25 s CPU), ~40 cold starts/month @ ~45 s for PaddleOCR model load. Backend **1 vCPU / 2 GiB** in **us-central1**, `--max-instances 2`, scale-to-zero. Container image ≈ 3 GB, 3 revisions retained. Frontend is a static Vite bundle (< 1 GB egress/month). No database — the app persists nothing.

A · THE RECURRING BILL, LINE BY LINE

METER	MONTHLY USE	FREE TIER	COST
Vercel Hobby static hosting	< 1 GB	100 GB	**$0.00**
Cloud Run requests	~2,000	2,000,000	**$0.00**
vCPU-seconds @ $0.000024	~3,700	180,000	**$0.00**
GiB-seconds @ $0.0000025	~7,400	360,000	**$0.00**
Cloud Build ~4 builds × 15 min	~60 min	120 min/day	**$0.00**
Egress XLSX / XML exports	< 1 GB	200 GB	**$0.00**
Artifact Registry @ $0.10/GB	~9 GB	0.5 GB	**$0.85**
Ongoing monthly total			**$0.85**

Every meter except image storage sits inside a permanent free allowance — these are **always-free** quotas that reset monthly, not credit-funded trials. **100% of the recurring bill is storing the Docker image**, which is large because `paddlepaddle` ships ~1 GB of wheels.

B · HOW THE BILL MOVES WITH VOLUME

INVOICES / MONTH	VCPU-S	COMPUTE	TOTAL/MO
200 — assumed today	3.7 K	**$0**	**$0.85**
1,000	10.5 K	**$0**	**$0.85**
5,000	44 K	**$0**	**$0.85**
20,000 — free-tier ceiling	172 K	**$0**	**$0.85**
40,000	342 K	**$4.70**	**$5.55**

At 2 GiB the CPU and memory free tiers exhaust at the same moment, so a single ceiling governs: **~21,000 invoices/month**, roughly **100× your current volume**. Past that you pay only for the excess — even **200×** today's load costs about **$5.55/mo (₹528)**. Cost is effectively flat across any plausible growth for a CA practice.

C · WHAT THE $300 CREDIT ACTUALLY DOES

At $0.85/month the credit is **mathematically impossible to spend** — you would burn about **$2.55 of it** before it **expires 90 days after signup**. It is not a runway; it is a safety net that absorbs mistakes (wrong region, a runaway instance count, an accidental always-on service) during setup. Plan the budget as if it does not exist — which is what this page does.

D · THE ONE WAY THIS BILL GROWS

IMAGE-RETENTION HABIT	STORED	$/MO	₹/MO
Prune to 3 revisions	9 GB	$0.85	₹81
Keep 12 months of deploys	~36 GB	$3.55	₹338
Never prune (2 yrs)	~72 GB	$7.15	₹681

Each redeploy writes another ~3 GB layer set. Left unmanaged, storage quietly becomes **8× the entire rest of the bill**. A one-line cleanup policy on the Artifact Registry repo removes this risk permanently.

E · IF YOU SWITCH TO AWS — SAME WORKLOAD, US-EAST-1

AWS SERVICE	RUNS YOUR DOCKERFILE?	SCALES TO ZERO?	COMPUTE	ECR + BUILD	$/MO	₹/MO	$/YR
Lambda container image, 3 GB, Function URL	**No — needs repackaging**	Yes	**$0.00**	$0.85	**$0.85**	₹81	$10
App Runner 2 GB, closest to Cloud Run	Yes	**No — idle memory billed 24×7**	**$10.29**	$2.15	**$12.44**	₹1,184	$149
ECS Fargate 1 vCPU / 2 GB, always on	Yes	No	**$36.04**	$0.85	**$36.89**	₹3,512	$443
Current stack — Cloud Run + Vercel Hobby runs your Dockerfile unmodified, scales to zero					**$0.85**	₹81	$10

Verdict: switching to AWS costs more or costs a rewrite — there is no version where it saves money. Lambda matches Cloud Run's $0.85 exactly, because its always-free tier (1 M requests + 400,000 GB-s, never expires) also swallows this workload — but Lambda cannot run your container as-is: it needs the Runtime Interface Client bolted in, caps execution at 15 min, and makes the PaddleOCR cold start worse. Every AWS service that *does* run your existing `Dockerfile` untouched bills idle time, costing **$12–$37/mo** for a service used a few hours a week. Cloud Run is the only option that is simultaneously drop-in, scale-to-zero, and free-tier-covered. Always-on alternatives (Lightsail 2 GB ≈ $12/mo, EC2 `t4g.small` + EBS ≈ $14/mo) land in the same $12–15 band and add server management you don't currently have.

WHAT TO DO

1. **Deploy to `us-central1`, not `asia-south1`.** The always-free tier applies only to Tier-1 US regions; Mumbai is Tier 2 — no free allowance and a higher per-second rate, which turns this $0 compute bill into a recurring charge. *This corrects the region currently written in `deploy.md`.* Cost of the change: ~200 ms extra latency, irrelevant beside a 25 s OCR pass.
2. **Set an Artifact Registry cleanup policy** keeping the 3 most recent versions. This is the only line item you actually pay, and the only one that can grow.
3. **Keep `--max-instances 2` and add a GCP budget alert at $5/mo.** With scale-to-zero the failure mode isn't gradual overspend, it's a misconfiguration — an always-on minimum instance would cost ~$13/mo, 15× the real bill, and the alert catches it in days.
4. **Do not add a warm instance to kill cold starts.** The ~60 s first-scanned-invoice delay is a UX cost, not a billing one; removing it would multiply your bill by 15. Prefer digital PDFs, which skip PaddleOCR entirely.
5. **Don't migrate to AWS on cost grounds.** The best case ties Cloud Run at $0.85 but demands a Lambda rewrite; the drop-in options cost 15–43× more. AWS also no longer offers a 12-month free tier — accounts opened after 15 July 2025 get $200 in credits for 6 months, then pay list price.

Basis. Rates verified August 2026: Cloud Run Tier-1 $0.000024/vCPU-s and $0.0000025/GiB-s, with 180,000 vCPU-s / 360,000 GiB-s / 2 M requests free every month; Artifact Registry $0.10/GB-month above 0.5 GB free; Vercel Hobby $0 (100 GB transfer, 6,000 build-minutes). **AWS us-east-1:** Lambda $0.20/M requests + $0.0000166667/GB-s with 1 M requests and 400,000 GB-s always free; App Runner $0.007/GB-hr provisioned + $0.064/vCPU-hr active + $0.005/build-min + $1/app/mo auto-deploy; Fargate $0.04048/vCPU-hr + $0.004445/GB-hr; ECR $0.10/GB-month. INR at **₹95.2/$** (8 Aug 2026). · Excludes a custom domain (~$12/yr, optional — the free `.vercel.app` and `.run.app` hostnames work). · **One flag, not a cost:** Vercel's Hobby plan is licensed for non-commercial use; if this tool is ever billed to clients, Vercel Pro at $20/seat-month would apply and would become ~96% of total spend. · Compare: **Render**, the alternative in `deploy.md`, needs its Standard plan ($25/mo) because PaddleOCR is OOM-killed below 2 GB — **29× this estimate**, billed 24×7 whether or not anyone uploads an invoice.